



Factors to Consider Working in Cybersecurity

☐ Learn about the company

It is important to know more than just what the company does. For instance, is the company growing, or has it laid employees off recently? Is this a start-up, or is the company established with a good history? Has it had any legal or financial problems in the recent past?

☐ Know why you are applying

Be able to explain why you are applying for a position. This is when the information you have gathered can be important and valuable.

☐ Consider the salary or hourly wage

What salary or hourly wage is acceptable to you for the position offered? Are there opportunities for overtime? In addition, the benefits package is important to understand. This can include stock, retirement, education, and insurance, both life and health. The number of days off, vacation days allowed, sick days, and whether work can be done from home (if needed) are important questions to ask or research as you look at possible employers. In line with this, you might want to determine how vacation days are earned and scheduled. For instance, as a new hire, you may be the last one who can request time off. If the office must be covered and others with seniority want the time off, you may have to be there. Education benefits may also be important depending on the career path you are seeking. Having the opportunity to get certifications, a degree or an advanced degree can be a great benefit. Benefits, or lack of them, can impact what is considered a fair wage or salary for a position.

☐ **Consider the values of the company**

Do the company's values and culture complement your values and cultural outlook? For example, does the company encourage volunteer work to help others and provide support to do this?

☐ **Consider the number of work hours**

The number of hours you will need to work or be expected or available to work is important. In addition, the days and the time shifts required should be considered. If you are an early riser, the night shift might not be a good idea. If the job is salaried, the more hours required, the less you make per hour. But if you are hourly, the extra hours can mean additional income.

☐ **What is the dress code?**

For instance, some companies require formal business attire, suits, and tie, even for technicians. Others are less formal. If a uniform is required, will it be provided? If specific clothing is required, is an allowance provided?

☐ **Are there travel requirements?**

You need to determine if any travel is required for the job. This could be between different local offices or longer overnight travel. If travel is required, how much and how often becomes important. In addition, how the travel is paid for can be important. There could be possible financial problems if you must pay for everything and then get reimbursed. This requires enough room on credit cards to take care of any necessary travel. However, if the company pays for most or all of the travel, this could simplify the situation. But it is better to know before rather than after you accept a position.

☐ **Consider the job location**

The job location is important. You need to know if you will need to relocate to take the job. If you must relocate, the cost of living in the new work area is important to understand. What appears to be a good salary or wage is not good if the job is in a more expensive area.

☐ **Consider the commute**

Whether you relocate or not, you need to understand what the average expected commute would be. You need to know if there are alternatives to driving and if you have to drive, whether there is adequate and affordable parking.

☐ **What are the job responsibilities?**

The job's responsibilities need to be examined or requested from the company. A job that does not vary may not be acceptable, nor one that changes constantly. This decision depends on your abilities and what you consider an ideal work environment. For many, a job with a combination of duties that changes, but not too fast, is ideal.

☐ **Is there an opportunity to move up?**

One important consideration is whether the company promotes from within. Such a company offers a better possibility for advancement and could help you advance a bit more rapidly. This policy might also make the company more desirable than a different company that hires mostly externally.

☐ **Consider the employee culture**

Research information about how current employees feel about those they work with and the overall work environment. Such reviews can be found on several different websites. Is the work environment you discover the type you would be comfortable in, and do the potential coworkers seem to be people you would enjoy working with?

☐ **Is there a work-life balance?**

You need to determine whether the job will allow a good work and life balance. This is especially important if you have a family. How would accepting the job affect your family? If you are single, will work allow you to have a life outside of work? Too often, those entering the workforce concentrate just on the amount of money to be made without considering other life issues that might need to be balanced with work.

Additional Considerations

When looking for a job in Cybersecurity remember that they may be looking for the following:

Soft Skills

Soft skills are personality traits that employers desire future employees to have. Most positions involving cybersecurity require the specialist to interface with people. You need to be able to listen actively and have good communication skills. You, the specialist, need to be creative and have good problem solving skills. In addition, you need to have logical thinking skills, make fast decision when necessary, pay attention to details and be able to work with others. Leadership ability is also important.

Hard Skills

Hard skills consist of technical knowledge and training. Hard skills are needed and should be learned as part of your more formal education. Some of the areas you will need to concentrate on and perhaps do some extra work to get are the basics of computer science (knowing computers, both hardware and operating system software).

Examples include:

- A working knowledge of a major programming language (C, C++, Java, C#)
- Familiarity with MITRE ATT&CK
- Understanding penetration attacks, vulnerability assessments, and performing them if needed
- Experience working in a team
- Knowledge of ethical hacking
- Working with Cisco hardware and software
- Knowledge of Security Information and Event Management (SIEM)

Education and Experience

The field of cybersecurity is changing rapidly. Actions taken in the past no longer work with today's attacks. Attackers are learning and using new and different tools and are becoming more sophisticated in their attacks. It is important to stay current with your knowledge. This learning can be done by utilizing continuing education. Continuing education is when someone who has already completed a certification or degree pursues additional learning opportunities.